‘strong gates, and the guards stand watch with the eye of caution for the slightest thing’. Inside are orchards, gardens, buildings, shops and bazaars. The king is Deva Raya II, ‘of perfect rule and hegemony’ with ‘around three hundred ports’ and an army of, Razzaq guesses, ‘more than a thousand elephants’ and 1.1 million men.[12] ‘In all of Hindustan,’ writes Razzaq, ‘there was no raja more autocratic than he’ and in whose ‘presence the Brahmins have great status’.

Razzaq is hosted in ‘extremely fine quarters’. When he meets the king, Razzaq offers him ‘five fine horses and two *toquzes* of damask silk and satin’. The youthful king, dressed in ‘a tunic of Zaytuni silk and a necklace of lustrous pearls’, receives him graciously and offers him the customary betel leaf and supari, thought to have amazing benefits for dental health and virility. He grants Razzaq a daily ration of ‘two sheep, four pairs of fowl, five maunds of rice, one maund of oil, one maund of sugar, and two gold *varahas* [large coins]’.

The king has many wives, ‘seven hundred ladies and concubines’, and he keeps ‘strict control over the affairs of each one’. Male kids, writes Razzaq, could stay with their mothers in the harem only until ten. ‘Throughout his realm wherever there is a beautiful girl, he persuades the girl’s mother and father and has her brought with much celebration to his harem. Thereafter no one sees her, but she is kept in great honor and veneration.’

About the city’s bazaars, he writes:[13]

> The bazaars are extremely broad and long. Flower sellers have tall platforms in front of the stalls, and on both sides they sell flowers . . . there are aromatic flowers continually in bloom, and as necessary as they deem food to be, they cannot bear [to be] without flowers. The practitioners of every craft have stalls adjacent to one another. The jewelers sell pearls, diamonds, rubies and emeralds openly in the bazaar . . . All nobles and commoners of the region, even the craftsmen of the bazaar, wear pearls and jewels in their ears, around their necks and on their arms, wrists and fingers.

The ‘elaborateness of their brothels,’ writes Razzaq, ‘or of the beauty, blandishments and attraction of their courtesans is beyond my ability to express’. Prostitutes, adorned ‘with costly pearls and jewels and fine clothing, are quite young and extremely beautiful, and with each stand one or two serving girls’. They ply their trade on attractive streets, waiting for customers on chairs outside rows of chambers ‘as clean as can be’. Taxes on their income, Razzaq claims, pay for the city’s police services. If the